LEAD MAGNET #11

6 Methods Beyond "Add More Weight"

The complete trainer's guide to progressive overload — with practical rules, rep-range chains, and an RPE-based progression system you can apply this week.

1. Increase Weight
2. Increase Reps
3. Increase Sets
4. Increase Tempo
5. Decrease Rest
6. Increase Frequency

Includes the **RPE-based progression rules** from EvoFit's built-in progression engine — the same system that automatically suggests overload for your clients based on real performance data.

1 Increase Weight

THE OBVIOUS ONE

The foundation of all progressive overload. Adding load is the clearest signal to force adaptation — but increment size matters as much as the act itself. Too much, too soon leads to breakdown rather than adaptation.

Upper body: +2.5–5 lbs per session when hitting top of rep range

Lower body: +5–10 lbs per session

Rule: Never add weight if form degraded last set

5lb AVG UPPER INCREMENT

2 Increase Reps

VOLUME LADDER

Hit the top of the rep range across all sets before progressing weight. This two-step model (reps first, then weight) prevents premature loading and builds a real strength base at each weight.

Protocol: Must complete ALL sets at top of range first

Then: Add weight, reset reps to bottom of range

3×8 @ 100lb → 3×9 → 3×10 → 3×8 @ 105lb

2 REP RANGE WIDTH

3 Increase Sets

VOLUME ACCUMULATION

Adding sets is the cleanest way to increase weekly volume per muscle group without touching load or reps. Use it to bridge plateau periods and to build volume tolerance before a loading phase. Diminishing returns kick in hard above 20+ sets per muscle group per week.

Rate: +1 set per exercise every 2–3 weeks

Ceiling: 20 sets/muscle group/week maximum

Deload when: performance drops despite equal or more sets

20 SETS/MUSCLE PER WEEK MAX

Trainer Tip: Methods 1–3 are your load and volume levers

Beginners respond to all three simultaneously. Intermediate and advanced clients need to periodize them — cycling through volume accumulation phases (sets + reps), then intensity phases (weight). Never try to progress all three in the same block.

4 Increase Tempo

TIME UNDER TENSION

Slowing down the eccentric (lowering) phase dramatically increases time under tension — one of the key drivers of hypertrophy — without adding a single pound. A paused squat at 100lb creates more stimulus than a fast squat at 110lb for most clients.

- **Slow eccentrics:** 3–4 second lowering phase
- **Paused reps:** 1–2s pause at bottom of ROM
- **1.5 reps:** full ROM + half ROM = one rep
- **Notation:** 3-1-1-0 (eccentric-pause-concentric-top)

3s ECCENTRIC TARGET

5 Decrease Rest Periods

METABOLIC DENSITY

Reducing rest time is a form of progressive overload — same work, less time = higher density = greater metabolic and cardiovascular demand. Best used during hypertrophy phases, not strength or peak phases where full recovery is needed for maximum force output.

- **Rate:** Reduce rest by 15 seconds every 2 weeks
- **Floor:** Never below 45s for compound movements
- **Avoid:** strength and peak phases (need full rest)

90s rest → 75s rest → 60s rest → Add load → reset to 90s

15s REDUCE EVERY 2 WKS

6 Increase Frequency

WEEKLY VOLUME

Training a muscle 2–3× per week delivers higher total weekly volume than 1× per week — without making any single session longer. This is the most underused overload tool for intermediate clients who have plateaued on a traditional body-part split.

- **Move from:** 1× per week per muscle group
- **Move to:** 2–3× per week
- **Distribute:** spread sets across sessions, not stacked
- **Recovery window:** minimum 48h between sessions for same muscle

2–3× PER MUSCLE PER WEEK

Trainer Tip: Methods 4–6 are your quality and frequency levers

These methods are your "secret weapons" when clients plateau. When weight stops going up, slow the tempo. When sessions feel stale, split the frequency. When conditioning is the goal, compress the rest. Each one provides a distinct training stimulus that weight alone cannot.

When to Use Each Method

Method	Goal: Strength	Goal: Hypertrophy	Goal: Endurance	Beginner	Intermediate	Advanced
1 · Increase Weight	★	✓	—	★	★	✓
2 · Increase Reps	✓	★	✓	★	✓	✓
3 · Increase Sets	✓	★	✓	Caution	★	✓
4 · Increase Tempo	—	★	✓	✓	★	✓
5 · Decrease Rest	—	✓	★	—	✓	★
6 · Increase Frequency	✓	★	✓	—	★	★

★ Best fit ✓ Works well — Not recommended Caution = monitor recovery carefully

RPE-Based Progression Rules

Auto-Progression Logic

From EvoFit's Progression Engine

RPE ≤6 **Too easy.** Increase weight next session. Client has significant reserve — don't wait.

RPE 7 **On track.** Continue current load. Target for hypertrophy work sets.

RPE 8 **Working range.** Hold load, focus on rep quality. Consider adding a set.

RPE 9 **Near max.** Reduce volume or load. Ensure adequate recovery before next session.

RPE 10 **True max.** Deload required. Not appropriate for hypertrophy training blocks.

Decline **Same weight, higher RPE than last session.** Flag for recovery review. Sleep, nutrition, or overtraining.

Track all 6 methods automatically.
EvoFit's progression engine does the math.

EvoFit Trainer auto-suggests which progression method to use next based on each client's RPE history, set completion, and training age — so you're coaching smarter, not harder.

✓ RPE-based auto-suggestions
✓ All 6 overload methods tracked
✓ Per-client progression history
✓ No monthly subscription

trainer.evofit.io/pricing

Starter $199 · Pro $299 · Enterprise $399